

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

This Very Moment is the Perfect Teacher
How to...Work Out What Matters Most

July 6th, 2025



"Boaters Rowing on the Yerres"
By Gustave Caillebotte, 1877

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Professor Bruce Neswick, Guest Organist

Praeludium in C-Dur, BuxWV 138 | Dietrich Buxtehude (1637-1707)

Aria | Flor Peeters (1903-1986)

Praeludium und Fuge in E-Moll, BWV 533 | J.S. Bach (1685-1750)

Toccata | Leo Sowerby (1895-1968)

Improvisation

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Words of Gathering

Rev. Tanaka Pack, Lance & Brittany Skiles

We walk a common road
but focus on different aspects of the journey.
Some of us look far into the distant past,
seeing the richness
of lives that have blessed us
into becoming who we now are.

Some of us bow our heads
and concentrate on each coming step,
carefully preparing us for each day's challenges.

Others of us peer into
the unknown spaces before us
longing to know that toward which we travel
and speaking words
of hope and promise as we journey.

And others, still,
eyes scanning the views on either side,
bless our steps with their lyric portrayal
of the beauty that surrounds us.

May we ever honor the gifts
each one of us brings to this journey.
May we ever have the courage to offer our own.

*This we ask, in this sacred time and place,
as people who are blessed with each other
and who share a sweeping vision of all that might yet be.*

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

O for a World

AZMON

O for a world where everyone respects each other's ways,
Where love is lived and all is done with justice and with praise.

O for a world where goods are shared and misery relieved,
Where truth is spoken, children spared, equality achieved.

We welcome one world family and struggle with each choice
That opens us to unity and gives our vision voice.

The poor are rich, the weak are strong, the foolish ones are wise.
Tell all who mourn, outcasts belong, who perishes will rise.

O for a world preparing for God's glorious reign of peace,
Where time and tears will be no more, and all but love will cease.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Eternal One,
Breathing in your spacious peace,
We welcome this day.

Resting in your expansive love,
We welcome this day.

Trusting in your perpetual hope,
We welcome this day.

Living in your created image,
We welcome this day.

May it be so for our world and all of us,
both on this day, and in all the days to come.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

"My Shepherd Will Supply My Need"
Cathedral Choir

VIRGIL THOMSON

***The Lord's Prayer**

Brittany Skiles

*Our God, who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

This morning may this truth of life and peace be with you all.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

A Reading from the Gospel

from John, chapter 21

Lance & Brittany Skiles

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Holy One, from the beginning, you have been with us on this journey of life.
As days unfold before us, you offer us invitations to discover, to dream, and to grow.
Since ancient times, you have been with humankind
through deserts on the way to unknown destinations.
Now in this, our time, we ask for the assurance
of your presence once again, as we embark on the next chapters
that will take us to unknown destinations.

*We pray for a journey that will stir our spirits, and stretch our minds.
We pray for a journey that will help us love our neighbors as ourselves
through the example of the Christ.*

In these days, help us Eternal One, to remember
that this journey will bring new ways of being
as it changes us, and the choices we must make.
Help us to discover the wisdom we need,
as we find our way in these difficult days.
And then, O God, help us to be mindful
that your grace and goodness are always
before us, around us, and within us.

*Even as we stumble and lose our way,
even when we find it hard to know what is right,
help us find a course that will allow us to regain
our true direction - a direction that is always focused
on your light and your love.*

Help us Gracious One, to end our longing for the past,
and help us find, in the here and now, all that we need.
Remind us that since this journey began long before
we took our place in the ever unfolding mystery,
turning back now is not an option.

*Remind us we must travel light, as we discard
the excess baggage from our past.
Remind us to cherish only that which is essential,
and to carefully choose the treasures, that will last forever.*

When we long, Holy One, to stop and end this journey,
when we want to set up camp and settle right where we are,
in an effort to avoid love's risk and pain
please disturb our complacent comfort,
please help us to pull the tent pegs up once again;
and keep travelling with us as we abide in the knowledge
that no matter where we go, you are always at our side.

*Give us, Holy One, the courage for this journey,
with the Christ as our goal, and the Spirit as our guide.*
[adapt/jdine]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Meditation Anthem

"To See A World"
Laude

SVEN DAVID SANDSTRÖM

*"To see a world in a grain of sand, and a heaven in a wild flower,
hold infinity in the palm of your hand and eternity in an hour." ~William Blake*

Sermon

This Very Moment is the Perfect Teacher

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Lance Skiles

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"You're Not Lost (You Are Here)"
Lorenzo Zapata, Frank Hobbs, Katelyn Dietz, and David Harris

J.J. HELLER & ANDY GULLAHORN,
arr. DAVID HARRIS

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Brittany Skiles

Holy One, we know each morning brings a newness
that we need but step into just as each of us has need.

May we be open to the power that lies dormant within us.
May we be full with a confidence in our own strength.
May we move from the routines that we follow
to the fullness of the lives we will live.

May it be so.
*May it be so for all of us,
both this day, and forever more.
Amen and Amen!*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

Inside each of us there awaits a wonder – a full spirit of freedom.
The Spirit of Freedom waits to dance in the rooms of our hearts
that are closed and cluttered.
The Spirit waits to dance in the spaces where negative feelings
have built barricades and stock-piled weapons.
The Spirit waits to dance in the corners where we still do not
believe in our goodness.
Inside each of us there awaits a wonder – full spirit of freedom
and she will lift light feet and make glad songs within us
on the day we open the door of our ego
and let the naysayers stomp out.

[Joyce Rupp]

And if we do...if we do – perhaps we might just change the world.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"I Remember, I Believe"
Cathedral Choir

BERNICE JOHNSON REAGON

***Hymn for the Journey**

O, Spirit of Power

LYONS

O Spirit of Power, who dwells in us all,
Inspire us each hour to follow your call.
Awaken our vision to all we can be,
And challenge our labor to set people free.

Though many your names, Love reigns over all;
With you we can claim our life-giving call.
Cast out all our fear so with you we can soar,
Creating a world never dreamed of before.

O Spirit of Love, compassionate Friend,
Within and above, your strength knows no end.
Your rivers of healing revive thirsty land;
All goodness and nourishment flow from your hand.

O Spirit of Power, O Love beyond thought,
Our gifts with you flower; what wonders are wrought.
Creator, Redeemer, and Comforting Guide,
Illumine our lives as with you we abide.

- lyrics by Jann Aldredge-Clanton

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Professor Bruce Neswick, Guest Organist

Pièce d'Orgue, BWV 572 | J.S. Bach (1685-1750)

Inside The Music

"After Luia was born, I started repeating the phrase "now is another now" to myself as a way to move more slowly through the world and enjoy each moment of her newness. From a neuroscience perspective, our brains function on predictions. Before we are aware of what's going to happen, our brains have made a decision about what we are going to do based on past experiences. This includes actions, feelings, reactions, etc. We are prediction machines. Our sensory awareness tools help us balance these predictions. After our brain makes a decision, our senses give us novel information about that moment that may challenge the predictions we live by. The more we develop awareness, the more we have a sense of "being in the moment." Sometimes our sensory awareness is so heightened that we feel as if time suspends and we are only in that moment. William Blake articulates such an experience in the opening lines of his poem "Auguries of Innocence" that Sandström set in his "To See A World." The piece opens with soft, undulating sounds. The singers are instructed to roll their tongues inside their mouths. The effect is one of a soft shimmer. He's creating a moment by giving us a chance to settle and heighten our awareness. As we are drawn into this subtle undulation, he slowly introduces one part at a time, teasing our brains. Each time we settle into predictions, we are entreated with something new to attract our awareness. As the opening lyrics are finally introduced, the piece has begun to swell. The second line "and a heaven in a wild flower" launches into a massive crescendo as the voices all rise into the upper part of their range. Out of nowhere, our brains' predictions are checked again, newness invites us into deeper presence. The rest of the piece is marked by frequent key changes and growth points. None of these leaps out so much, as the subtle and constant changes mirror life. Our brain's predictions are lies in many ways. We create our own reality. Yet, when we develop sensory awareness, we have a greater chance of enjoying the fruits of this moment, and of engaging with the truths that only our senses can behold. As I chanted "now is another now" in my head, I was reminded to listen, feel, smell, taste and see the world around me. I was drawn into the discovery of our newborn by allowing my own rebirth in every moment through the gift of my senses, thereby allowing me to learn more readily from the existence of now." – Dr. David Harris

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